



"History doesn't repeat itself, but it often rhymes" — Mark Twain

How poignant and poetic that in what was likely Rafael Nadal's last Roland Garros, another swashbuckling Spaniard seized the mantle with his first title. When Carlos Alcaraz fell on his back to celebrate his five-set final victory over Alexander Zverev, it evoked indelible memories of Nadal.

The immortal King of Clay had rejoiced the same way after his record 14 titles. A touch of irony added to the broad sweep of history as Zverev beat the aging, fading Nadal in the first round only to have his compatriot successor stymie the German in the last round.

In the first French Open final without a member of the Big Three since 2004, Alcaraz became the youngest man, at 21, to capture a Grand Slam title on hard, clay, and grass courts, edging Nadal, who, at 22, completed the feat at the 2009 Australian Open.

This fortnight the Spanish sorcerer had to come back from being down

Valiant in defeat: Even though Alexander Zverev led their rivalry 5-4, Alcaraz was better in just about every other category, except perhaps Zverev's rock-solid backhand. AFP

two sets to one against Jannik Sinner in the semifinals and again in the dramatic final. Alcaraz must relish long matches as much to show off his repertoire of dazzling shots as his zeal for competition.

"Alcaraz is the greatest shot-maker in tennis, but sometimes he plays more with his heart than his head," noted Carillo.

That audacity has endeared Alcaraz to fans worldwide, but living dangerously also got him into trouble on occasion. Even so, *The Telegraph* (UK) made him a big betting favorite with 11-10 odds, while Zverev had 5-1 odds.

Even though both players were contesting their first French Open final, Alcaraz prevailed in his previous Grand Slam finals at the 2022 US Open and the 2023 Wimbledon, upsetting seven-time champion

Novak Djokovic. In sharp contrast, Zverev faltered after coming within two points of the title at the 2020 US Open against Dominic Thiem.

Before this final, the candid Zverev discussed the heartbreaking setback: "I've said it before and I'm going to say it now again: I was not ready. I was not ready to win my first Grand Slam final. I was not mature enough. I was maybe too much of a kid still. I didn't know what the occasion meant. And that's why I lost. I'm 27 years old now. So definitely not a kid anymore. Already getting older. If not now, then when?"

Not this time. Even though Zverev led their rivalry 5-4, rode an 11-match clay winning streak after taking the Rome Masters, and boasted the best first serve in tennis, Alcaraz was better in just about every other category, except perhaps Zverev's rock-solid backhand. **Alcaraz enjoyed big advantages on the forehand and serve, shot variety, athleticism, and the ability to handle pressure.**

Neither dealt well with the pressure to start the match. Zverev